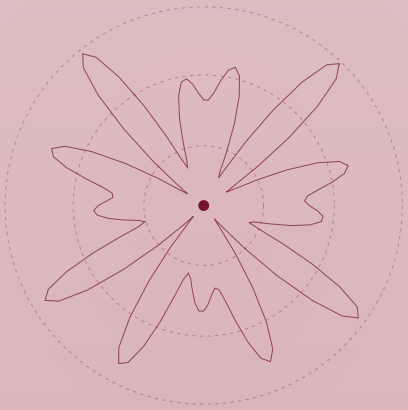
Emotions



Fear, Anger, Joy, Grief, Love,
and Seven Other Everyday Feelings
in Twelve Highlights Each

PSYCHOLOGY & BEHAVIOR

Emotions

Fear, Anger, Joy, Grief, Love, and Seven Other Everyday Feelings in Twelve Highlights Each

CONTENTS

— **Introduction**
Why Everyday Feelings Are Survival Tools Built Into the Body

1. **Fear**
Freezing in Place, False Alarms, and the Woman Who Poked a Haunted-House Monster

2. **Anger**
Boiling Blood, Costly Payback, and Why Losing Your Temper Protects You From Bullies

3. **Joy**
Crinkled Eye Corners, Contagious Smiles, and the Difference Between Wanting and Liking

4. **Sadness and Grief**
Broken-Heart Adrenaline, Chemical Tears, and Why Bereavement Feels Like Withdrawal

5. **Love and Attachment**
Prairie Vole Pair Bonds, Mother's Milk Hormones, and Holding a Partner's Hand in Pain

6. **Disgust**
Cockroach Juice, Chocolate Fudge, and How a Rotten-Food Reflex Turned Into Moral Outrage

7. **Guilt and Shame**
The Urge to Hide Versus the Urge to Fix What You Broke

8. **Envy and Jealousy**
Cucumber Tantrums, Silver-Medal Frowns, and the Pain of Watching a Rival Win

9. **Embarrassment**
Why Only Humans Blush and How Turning Red Wins Instant Forgiveness

10. **Laughter and Play**
Ticklish Rats, Play Bows, and Why Group Laughter Bonds Strangers

11. **Nostalgia**
Swiss Mercenary Homesickness, Cold-Room Warmth, and How Old Songs Steady the Mind

12. **Gratitude and Awe**
Overview Astronauts, Towering Redwood Trees, and How Feeling Small Makes Us Generous

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Emotions

Why Everyday Feelings Are Survival Tools Built Into the Body

For centuries, philosophers treated emotions as messy glitches that got in the way of clear thinking. If you jumped at a shadow or lost your temper over a small insult, people assumed your rational mind had temporarily lost control. The same was true when you cried over a movie or blushed until your ears burned.

Modern experiments tell a completely different story. Your feelings are not mistakes. They are fast, automatic survival tools built to handle problems that slow, logical thinking solves too late. If you step toward a coiled snake on a trail, you cannot wait while your conscious brain calmly analyzes the scales and calculates the risk. You need an alarm that freezes your legs in twelve thousandths of a second and asks questions later.

Even feelings that seem painful or embarrassing do real work behind the scenes. Anger makes sure bullies know you will fight back even when fighting costs you money. Disgust started as a reflex to spit out rotten meat and grew into our sense of fairness. Guilt nudges us to fix the friendships we damage. A red blush proves to a room that we are sorry in a way no liar can fake. Looking closely at twelve everyday feelings reveals the clever physical tricks running beneath everything we feel.

CHAPTER 1

Fear

Freezing in Place, False Alarms, and the Woman Who Poked a Haunted-House Monster

When you hear a loud crack in the woods, the sound travels from your ears along two separate brain tracks at the same time. In 1986, neuroscientist Joseph LeDoux showed that a fast shortcut reaches your brain's alarm center in just twelve milliseconds. That shortcut makes you jump before your slower thinking cortex figures out whether the stick is a snake twenty-four milliseconds later.

• • •

Most people talk about fight or flight, but your body's very first reaction to danger is actually to freeze solid. For a full second, your heart rate briefly slows down and your muscles lock in place. Predators have eyes wired to spot movement, so staying still gives you the best chance of going unnoticed.

• • •

Why do your hands turn icy cold and clammy when you are terrified? Adrenaline squeezes shut the tiny blood vessels in your skin and fingers so that extra blood can rush straight to your leg muscles. That blood shift also means you bleed less if a predator claws or bites your skin.

• • •

When fear hits, your pupils open wide to let in more light. At the same time, you lose your side vision and your ability to focus on tiny details close up. Tiny muscles in your middle ear also stiffen to muffle low background rumbles so you can hear high-pitched footsteps or branches snapping.

• • •

Why do people say their hair stood on end when they were scared? Every hair on your arms and neck is attached to a microscopic muscle that pulls the hair upright when adrenaline surges. It is a leftover reflex from furry ancestors who puffed up their coat to look twice as big to an enemy.

• • •

Beginning in the 1990s at the University of Iowa, doctors studied a woman known as Patient S.M., whose two almond-shaped amygdala alarm hubs had been destroyed by calcium buildup. Her memory and intelligence were completely normal. However, she could not feel fear toward anything in the outside world.

• • •

When researchers took Patient S.M. to an exotic pet store, she walked right up to the glass and asked to hold a live python and a tarantula. Later they led her through one of the scariest haunted houses in Kentucky. She never flinched once and actually scared one of the hidden actors by poking his mask.

• • •

Without fear, Patient S.M. also had a blind spot for reading other people's faces. She could easily recognize happy, sad, or angry faces in photographs, but she could not tell when someone looked terrified. Researchers soon noticed why: she never looked at people's eyes, and wide-open white eyes are the main visual signal of fear.

• • •

Even more surprising, Patient S.M. had no sense of personal space. Most volunteers step back when a stranger walks within two feet of them. She stood nose-to-nose with complete strangers without feeling the slightest discomfort, showing that the same brain hub that fears snakes also guards our personal bubble.

• • •

Yet in 2013, researchers discovered one thing that still terrified Patient S.M. When she inhaled a single breath of air mixed with 35 percent carbon dioxide, she suffered a full panic attack within ten seconds and tore off her mask. The terror of suffocating is wired into the deep brainstem rather than the amygdala.

• • •

Monkeys raised in a lab have zero fear of snakes the first time they see one. Yet they learn to fear snakes after watching a single video of another monkey acting scared of a snake. If researchers edit that video so the monkey appears terrified of a flower instead, the watching monkeys do not become afraid of flowers.

Can another person literally smell your fear? Researchers collected sweat pads from first-time skydivers and had volunteers sniff them inside a brain scanner without knowing where the sweat came from. The skydiver sweat quietly woke up the volunteers' own fear circuits and made them jumpier at loud noises.

CHAPTER 2

Anger

Boiling Blood, Costly Payback, and Why Losing Your Temper Protects You From Bullies

Both fear and anger flood your bloodstream with adrenaline, yet they push your blood in opposite directions. At the University of California, San Francisco, psychologists Paul Ekman and Robert Levenson measured skin temperature during different emotions. While fear chills your fingers, anger heats your hands up by more than a full degree Celsius as blood rushes to your fists and face.

• • •

Suppose a thief steals your wallet containing a hundred dollars. He knows it would cost you five hundred dollars in time and trouble to track him down. A purely cold, calculating person would walk away because spending five hundred to recover one hundred is a bad deal—which means thieves could rob cold calculators all day long.

• • •

Economist Robert Frank pointed out that anger solves that exact trap. When everyone knows you have a hot temper that will make you spend five hundred dollars to punish a hundred-dollar theft regardless of the cost, your threat becomes believable. Thieves leave your wallet alone in the first place.

• • •

In 1982, economist Werner Güth tested this in a simple money experiment called the Ultimatum Game. One player is handed ten dollars and proposes how to split it with a second player. If the second player says yes, both keep the money, but if the second player says no, neither gets a dime.

• • •

Logical math says the second player should accept even a single dollar, since one dollar is better than zero. In real life, whenever a greedy partner offers eight dollars for himself and two dollars for the other person, angry players reject the deal over half the time. They happily burn two dollars just to wipe the smile off a cheater's face.

• • •

Brain scans of people playing the Ultimatum Game show a tug-of-war inside the head during an unfair offer. The emotional disgust-and-anger hub lights up to demand rejection, while the calculating front of the brain tries to take the free cash. When researchers temporarily quiet that front area with magnets, people accept unfair offers without complaint.

• • •

Almost every mammal bares its teeth when angry, and humans do the same by pulling the lips back into a square snarl. Modern adults rarely bite their enemies in an argument. Even so, our face still uncovers the upper canine teeth while pulling the eyebrows down low to shield the eyes from a punch.

• • •

Why does counting to ten actually help when you lose your temper? A burst of adrenaline and stress chemicals peaks in your bloodstream within a few seconds. However, if no fresh trigger arrives, your liver and blood enzymes clear half of that initial adrenaline rush within roughly ninety seconds.

• • •

For decades, pop psychology advised angry people to vent by punching a pillow or screaming to let off steam like a pressure cooker. When psychologist Brad Bushman tested this on hundreds of angry volunteers, the pressure-cooker theory failed completely. People who hit a punching bag became significantly more aggressive afterward than people who simply sat quietly for two minutes.

• • •

Most brain-wave activity linked to pulling away and hiding happens on the right side of the front cortex. Brain activity linked to moving forward and chasing goals happens on the left. Uniquely among negative feelings, anger lights up the left go-forward side of the brain—the exact same side activated by excitement and determination.

• • •

While anxiety makes people overestimate every risk in the room, anger does the exact opposite. In experiments by psychologist Jennifer Lerner, angry volunteers judged future risks—from car accidents to financial gambles—as much safer and more controllable than sad or anxious volunteers.

That blind spot makes anger the most reckless of all negative feelings.

• • •

Chronic, simmering hostility is hard on the heart for a physical reason. When you stay angry in traffic or arguments day after day, surges of stress hormones scrape the delicate inner lining of your coronary arteries and make blood platelets stickier. That surge doubles the short-term risk of a heart attack in the two hours after an outburst.

CHAPTER 3

Joy

Crinkled Eye Corners, Contagious Smiles, and the Difference Between Wanting and Liking

In 1862 in Paris, physician Guillaume Duchenne used gentle electrical probes on human faces to prove that there are two completely different kinds of smiles. A polite, fake smile only uses the cheek muscles to pull up the corners of the mouth. A real smile of joy also squeezes the circular muscles around the eye sockets, crinkling the skin at the outer corners.

• • •

Nearly anyone can fake the mouth part of a smile on command for a camera. However, fewer than one in ten people can consciously flex the outer ring of eye muscle without actually feeling happy. That makes the crow's-feet crinkle around the eyes nature's built-in truth detector for genuine warmth.

• • •

In 2001, psychologists LeeAnne Harker and Dacher Keltner examined the 1960 college yearbook photographs of 141 women at Mills College without knowing anything else about their lives. Women who flashed genuine eye-crinkling smiles in their college photo at age twenty-one were more likely to be happily married later in life. They also reported higher personal well-being thirty years later at age fifty-two.

• • •

For decades, scientists assumed dopamine was the brain's pleasure chemical. Then neuroscientist Kent Berridge at the University of Michigan proved that dopamine actually controls *wanting*—craving and chasing a reward. True *liking*—the warm pleasure of enjoying it—comes from tiny opioid and cannabinoid hotspots less than a cubic millimeter wide.

• • •

When Berridge gave rats a drop of sugar water, they licked their lips in a universal mammalian pleasure face that human babies also make. When he wiped out 99 percent of the dopamine in the rats' brains, they stopped walking over to the sugar spout. Yet if a drop of sugar was placed on their tongue, they still made the exact same happy lip-licking face.

• • •

Why do we feel happier when an unexpected twenty-dollar bill turns up in an old coat pocket than when we receive our regular paycheck? Neuroscientist Wolfram Schultz discovered that reward cells in the brain do not fire based on how big a prize is. Instead, they fire based on the surprise gap between what you expected and what you actually got.

• • •

In 1978, psychologists Philip Brickman, Dan Coates, and Ronnie Janoff-Bulman interviewed major state lottery winners and compared them with ordinary neighbors. Within a year of winning up to a million dollars, the lottery winners

were no happier in their day-to-day mood than the non-winners. They actually took less pleasure in small everyday joys like eating breakfast or talking with a friend.

• • •

Sadness narrows your focus so you stare at a single problem, whereas joy literally widens what your eyes take in. In eye-tracking experiments by psychologist Barbara Fredrickson, volunteers shown a joyful film clip scanned a wider field of view. They also solved creative word puzzles faster than volunteers in a neutral or anxious mood.

• • •

When you see a friend smile, you do not just recognize the expression with your eyes. Your own face copies it within a third of a second. Muscle sensors taped to volunteers' cheeks show that looking at a smiling face triggers tiny, invisible twitches in your own smiling muscles before you even realize it.

• • •

Does forcing your face into a smile or holding your body upright actually change how you feel? In 2022, Nicholas Coles led an international study of 3,878 volunteers across nineteen countries to test the facial-feedback idea. Consciously smiling produced a small but measurable lift in happiness, especially when people copied a natural smile rather than biting a pen.

• • •

Across the globe, blind athletes who have never seen a human face in their lives throw their arms up in a V-shape, tilt their chin back, and smile the moment they win a match at the Paralympic Games. They make the exact same gesture as sighted athletes, proving that the posture of triumph is born in us rather than learned from television.

• • •

Spending money on other people reliably produces more lasting joy than spending the exact same amount on yourself. Psychologist Elizabeth Dunn handed envelopes of cash to volunteers on a sidewalk and checked their mood that evening. People instructed to buy a gift or coffee for someone else were significantly happier at the end of the day than those told to treat themselves.

CHAPTER 4

Sadness and Grief

Broken-Heart Adrenaline, Chemical Tears, and Why Bereavement Feels Like Withdrawal

Humans are the only animals on Earth known to shed tears in response to emotional pain. Every other land mammal produces tears strictly to lubricate the eyeball and wash out dust. For decades, that left biologists puzzled over why human grief spills salty water down the cheeks.

• • •

In 1981, biochemist William Frey collected tears from volunteers who cried while watching sad movies and compared them in the lab with tears from volunteers who chopped raw onions. The emotional tears contained 24 percent more protein than the onion tears. They also carried stress hormones and natural painkillers called enkephalins.

• • •

Crying works as an unmistakable visual and chemical signal that disarms anger in others. Neuroscientist Noam Sobel had men sniff real emotional tears collected from women, which have zero conscious odor. The men's testosterone levels and aggressive arousal dropped within minutes, even though they thought they were sniffing plain salt water.

• • •

What is that hard, aching lump in the throat you feel right before you cry? When sadness triggers your fight-or-flight nerves while you try to hold back sobs, your body widens the windpipe flap—the glottis—to pull in extra oxygen. Swallowing against that wide-open flap feels like a golf ball stuck in your throat.

• • •

Can a person literally die of a broken heart? In 1969, British psychiatrist Colin Murray Parkes tracked 4,486 widowers after the death of their wives. During the first six months of grief, their death rate jumped 40 percent above married men of the same age, mostly from sudden heart failure and blood clots.

• • •

In 1990, Japanese cardiologists identified the medical mechanism behind sudden heartbreak: *takotsubo cardiomyopathy*, named after a round-bottomed octopus trap. A massive surge of grief adrenaline stuns the bottom half of the heart's main pumping chamber so it balloons out and stops squeezing. It mimics a massive heart attack even when the coronary arteries are completely clear.

• • •

Why does losing someone you love feel like physical pain in your chest? Psychologists Naomi Eisenberger and Matthew Lieberman scanned volunteers who were suddenly excluded or rejected. The loss lit up the exact same pain-alarm areas of the brain that fire when your hand is burned—and tak-

ing ordinary acetaminophen pain relievers actually dulled people's hurt feelings over daily social rejection.

• • •

When neuroscientist Mary-Frances O'Connor scanned the brains of grieving women looking at photos of a lost loved one, she discovered why deep grief is so hard to let go. In prolonged grief, the brain's reward and craving center keeps firing for the missing person. That turns bereavement into a literal state of neurological withdrawal.

• • •

When you are sad, the world actually looks slightly dimmer and less colorful. In controlled vision tests at the University of Rochester, volunteers who had just watched a sad film clip took a color-perception test. They were noticeably worse at telling apart shades of blue and yellow than volunteers who watched a comedy clip.

• • •

Although mild sadness hurts, it makes people sharper and more careful thinkers than cheerful moods do. In experiments by Australian psychologist Joseph Forgas, mildly sad volunteers remembered eyewitness details more accurately and fell for fewer fake rumors. They also wrote clearer, more persuasive arguments than happy volunteers who relied on gut hunches.

• • •

After a devastating loss, people shrink their posture, speak in a flat, quiet tone, and lose interest in hobbies. Evolutionary psychiatrists Randolph Nesse and Paul Andrews noted that this slowdown serves a real purpose. It forces a person to stop chasing failed goals, saves energy, and signals friends and family to step in with food and care.

• • •

Across dozens of bereavement studies tracked by psychologist George Bonanno, most people are far tougher than they expect before a loss occurs. Roughly 10 to 15 percent of bereaved spouses suffer prolonged, multi-year grief. However, more than half return to steady emotional footing within months while cherishing warm memories of the person they lost.

CHAPTER 5

Love and Attachment

Prairie Vole Pair Bonds, Mother's Milk Hormones, and Holding a Partner's Hand in Pain

Out of all five thousand species of mammals on Earth, fewer than five percent form lifelong monogamous couples. Most mammal fathers leave right after mating. That rarity made biologists wonder what flips the switch inside the few species—like humans, beavers, gibbons, and tiny prairie voles—that stay together for life.

• • •

Neuroscientists Sue Carter, Thomas Insel, and Larry Young solved the mystery by comparing two nearly identical rodent cousins. The prairie vole mates for life, shares a nest, and raises pups together. By contrast, the closely related montane vole is a total loner that abandons its mate immediately after sex.

• • •

The difference between the faithful prairie vole and the promiscuous montane vole comes down to where two hormones—oxytocin and vasopressin—land in the brain. In prairie voles, sensors for those two bonding hormones are packed right inside the brain's reward center. Mating links that specific partner's scent to a lifelong rush of reward.

• • •

Larry Young used a harmless virus to copy that single prairie-vole hormone-sensor gene into the reward center of promiscuous meadow voles. The playboy rodents transformed overnight. They suddenly cuddled with a single female partner and ignored new strangers, showing how one genetic tweak wires pair bonding.

• • •

In human beings, early romantic infatuation looks remarkably like an obsession on a brain scan. Anthropologist Helen Fisher and neuroscientist Lucy Brown scanned college students who had just fallen madly in love. Looking at their sweetheart's photo lit up the exact same primitive dopamine engine activated by cocaine or a slot machine jackpot.

• • •

Early love also turns down the brain's critical judgment. In brain scans by Semir Zeki and Andreas Bartels in London, gazing at a romantic partner quieted both the fear center and the frontal circuits we normally use to spot other people's flaws. That neural switch gives a real biological basis to the old saying that love is blind.

• • •

Holding the hand of someone you love works like a physical painkiller. In 2006 at the University of Virginia, psychologist James Coan gave married women mild electric shocks to the ankle inside an MRI scanner. Holding a stranger's hand calmed the brain's threat alarm slightly, but holding a loving husband's hand quieted the alarm almost completely.

• • •

In 2018, neuroscientist Pavel Goldstein wired romantic couples to EEG caps while the woman touched a hot probe on her arm. Simply holding her partner's hand caused both partners' brain waves, heart rates, and breathing rhythms to lock into the same frequency. The tighter their brain waves synchronized, the more her pain faded.

• • •

Why do adults all over the world automatically talk to babies—and to puppies—in a high-pitched, sing-song voice with stretched-out vowels? Infant hearing studies show that newborns tune out normal adult conversation. By contrast, that exaggerated melody grabs a baby's attention, slows their heart rate, and helps them map vowel sounds twice as fast.

• • •

Skin-to-skin hugging does not rely on ordinary touch nerves that tell you whether a surface is rough or smooth. Instead, our hairy skin on the arms, shoulders, and back is wired with a separate set of slow cuddle nerves. Those nerves fire most strongly when stroked at about one inch per second at human skin temperature.

• • •

When humans and their pet dogs gaze into each other's eyes for five minutes, oxytocin levels jump by 130 percent in the dogs and 300 percent in their human owners. When Japanese biologist Takefumi Kikusui ran the exact same test with

hand-raised wolves, eye contact produced zero hormone surge. Dogs hijacked our parent-baby bonding loop during domestication.

• • •

The Harvard Study of Adult Development tracked 724 men for more than eighty years in the longest study of human life ever conducted. Psychiatrist Robert Waldinger found that neither cholesterol levels, IQ, nor wealth at age fifty predicted who would stay healthy and sharp at age eighty. The single strongest predictor was how warm and trustworthy their close relationships were.

CHAPTER 6

Disgust

Cockroach Juice, Chocolate Fudge, and How a Rotten-Food Reflex Turned Into Moral Outrage

In 1986 at the University of Pennsylvania, psychologist Paul Rozin fed hungry students a piece of delicious chocolate fudge. Then he took a second piece from the exact same wrapper and molded it into the realistic shape of dog feces. Almost none of the students would put it in their mouth, even though they had watched him unwrap the chocolate.

• • •

Next, Rozin poured two glasses of fresh apple juice and pulled a dead cockroach out of a sterile medical autoclave bag guaranteed free of germs. He dipped the sterile bug into one glass for five seconds and took it out. Volunteers flatly refused to drink a single drop, proving that once our disgust alarm tags something as contaminated, logic cannot wash it clean.

• • •

Why is the disgust reflex so stubborn and irrational? For millions of years before microscopes, a single invisible speck of bacteria on rotting meat or dirty water could multiply inside the gut and kill you. Evolution wired a hair-trigger rule: if anything resembles waste or touches decay for even a second, throw the whole meal away.

• • •

Strangely, babies and toddlers do not feel disgust at all. Children under age two or three happily put dirt, bugs, and even feces into their mouths without wrinkling their nose. The disgust circuit only switches on between ages three and five after children watch what their parents refuse to touch.

• • •

Look closely at the face someone makes when they smell spoiled milk: the upper lip curls up and the bridge of the nose wrinkles. Charles Darwin noticed that this expression serves a mechanical job. Wrinkling the nose narrows the nasal passages to block bad fumes, while curling the upper lip helps push bad food off the tongue.

• • •

Whereas fear and anger make your heart beat faster to pump blood to your muscles, seeing a gruesome wound or maggots actually slows your heart rate down. Disgust triggers the vagus nerve to drop your blood pressure and churn your stomach. That reflex prepares your digestive tract to vomit out poison rather than run a race.

• • •

In 2000, neuroscientists in Cambridge studied a man known as Patient N.K., whose stroke damaged a small fold of brain tissue called the insula. Although he could still recognize happy, sad, and frightened faces without trouble, he could no longer tell when someone else looked disgusted. He also stopped feeling disgusted by moldy food himself.

• • •

Why do people say a crooked politician or a betrayal leaves a bad taste in the mouth? In 2009, psychologist Hanah Chapman wired muscle sensors to volunteers' faces while they played a money game. Being cheated out of cash made people flex the exact same upper-lip-curling muscle they used when swallowing bitter quinine water.

• • •

Even more remarkably, washing your hands changes how harshly you judge other people's morals. In classic experiments by Chen-Bo Zhong and Katie Liljenquist, volunteers recalled an unethical deed of their own and were offered a free gift. They were twice as likely to choose an antiseptic hand wipe over a pencil—as if scrubbing the skin could wash away a dirty conscience.

• • •

Why does our own saliva feel completely fine inside our mouth, yet the moment we spit that exact same saliva into a clean glass, drinking it back feels revolting? Psychologist Gordon Allport pointed out why. The moment a bodily fluid crosses outside the skin boundary, the brain reclassifies it from part of me to a foreign biohazard.

• • •

Yet parents and lovers have a built-in override switch for that rule. In blinded smell tests by Trevor Case and Betty Repacholi, mothers smelled identical dirty diapers with the labels switched so they had to judge by scent alone. Mothers

consistently rated their own baby's dirty diaper as far less disgusting than a stranger's baby's diaper.

• • •

Sexual arousal also temporarily turns down the volume on the brain's disgust alarm. At the University of Groningen, psychologist Charmaine Borg tested women who were sexually aroused before a lab task. They were far more willing to touch gross objects—like a used comb or a live worm in a bowl—than unaroused control volunteers.

CHAPTER 7

Guilt and Shame

The Urge to Hide Versus the Urge to Fix What You Broke

People use the words guilt and shame as if they mean the same thing. Yet psychologist June Tangney proved across thirty years of research that they pull human behavior in opposite directions. Guilt says *I did something bad*, whereas shame says *I am a bad person*.

• • •

That small shift in focus changes everything that happens next. When people feel guilt over hurting a friend, they lean forward, confess, apologize, and look for ways to fix the damage. When people feel shame, they feel exposed and worthless, making them want to sink through the floor, hide the mistake, or lash out at whoever caught them.

• • •

You can spot shame in a person's body posture across every culture on Earth. The head drops, the chin tucks into the chest, the shoulders roll inward, and the eyes look down or away. It is the exact submissive posture primates and wolves use to shrink their body size and ask a dominant group member not to attack.

• • •

In 2014, Tangney and her colleagues tracked 476 county jail inmates from the week they entered jail until a year after they were released back into the community. Inmates who felt genuine guilt about their crimes were significantly less likely to commit new offenses. Shame-prone inmates blamed other people for their troubles and returned to jail at higher rates.

• • •

Toddlers start showing these self-conscious feelings right around their second birthday, as soon as they can recognize their own reflection in a mirror. Psychologist Michael Lewis handed two-year-olds a rigged doll whose leg fell off in their hands. Guilt-prone toddlers tried to fix the leg and told the adult right away, while shame-prone toddlers slumped their shoulders and hid the doll.

• • •

When you feel guilty about letting someone down, you become unusually generous to the next person you meet. In classic experiments by Carlsmith and Gross, volunteers were tricked into thinking they had ruined a student's lab experiment. Afterward, they were three times more likely to agree to make dozens of tedious volunteer phone calls to clear their conscience.

• • •

Why does confessing a secret off your chest actually make your body feel lighter? Psychologist James Pennebaker found that keeping a shameful secret requires constant men-

tal effort and raises stress hormones. Writing down a hidden mistake for just fifteen minutes a day over four days measurably boosted immune-cell activity and cut doctor visits over the following months.

• • •

Parents and teachers can accidentally trigger shame instead of guilt with a single word choice. Telling a child who spilled juice that they made a mess and can grab a towel to wipe it up targets the action and builds helpful guilt. Asking the child why they are so clumsy attacks their identity and triggers defensive shame.

• • •

Some people carry an overactive guilt alarm known as survivor's guilt. First documented among Holocaust survivors and soldiers whose friends died beside them in combat, the brain treats surviving a random tragedy as if it were an unfair selfish theft from those who died. Survivors punish themselves even when they did nothing wrong.

• • •

Across cultures, anthropologists Ruth Benedict and Ying Wong noticed that communities rely on different mixes of the two feelings. Tight-knit honor and family cultures often use public shame to keep people in line with group rules. Mobile, individualist societies rely more on private guilt that follows a person even when no neighbors are watching.

• • •

Does everyone have a guilt alarm? Roughly one percent of the general population—and up to twenty percent of maximum-security prisoners—score high in clinical psychopathy. Brain scans by neuroscientist Kent Kiehl show underactive wiring between their emotional amygdala and decision-making front cortex, leaving them able to recite moral rules out loud without feeling a twinge of remorse.

• • •

Yet for the other ninety-nine percent of us, a healthy dose of guilt is the glue that holds friendships and marriages together. Couple studies show that partners who readily feel guilt after forgetting an errand or snapping in an argument apologize faster. They also listen better to their partner's hurt feelings and enjoy more stable relationships.

CHAPTER 8

Envy and Jealousy

Cucumber Tantrums, Silver-Medal Frowns, and the Pain of Watching a Rival Win

Although people mix up envy and jealousy every day, psychologists separate them by counting how many people are in the room. *Envy* is a two-person feeling when you want something somebody else has. *Jealousy* is a three-person alarm when you fear losing someone's love or attention to a rival.

• • •

In 2003 at Emory University, primatologists Sarah Brosnan and Frans de Waal proved that monkeys feel hot envy over unequal pay. A capuchin monkey happily handed over a small pebble in exchange for a slice of cucumber twenty-five times in a row. Then she saw the monkey in the cage next door get a sweet grape for the exact same pebble—and she hurled the cucumber slice straight back at the researcher.

• • •

We do not envy billionaires on another continent nearly as much as we envy the neighbor or coworker sitting one desk over. Philosopher Bertrand Russell and social psychologist Leon Festinger pointed out this local comparison rule. Beggars do not envy millionaires; they envy other beggars who get slightly bigger handouts on the same street corner.

• • •

In 1995, psychologists Victoria Medvec, Scott Madey, and Thomas Gilovich covered up the jersey numbers on television footage from the 1992 Barcelona Olympics and asked viewers to rate how happy the winners looked on the podium. Bronze medalists in third place looked far happier than silver medalists in second place. The bronze winner compares himself to finishing fourth with nothing, while the silver winner tortures himself over losing gold.

• • •

Neuroscientist Hidehiko Takahashi put college students inside an fMRI brain scanner in Tokyo and had them read about a rival student who shared their exact major but had a better job, higher grades, and a wealthier partner. The envy lit up the dorsal anterior cingulate cortex—the exact same brain region that registers physical pain.

• • •

In a second part of that same Tokyo experiment, the students read that their successful rival had just suffered food poisoning or lost their prestigious job. Instantly, the pain center turned off and the brain's reward center lit up like a slot machine. That neural flip captures the German word *Schadenfreude*, or taking secret pleasure in a rival's stumble.

• • •

Psychologists Niels van de Ven, Marcel Zeelenberg, and Rik Pieters discovered that languages like Dutch, Polish, and Thai have two separate words for two very different kinds of

envy. *Malicious envy* wants to pull the winner down off their pedestal. *Benign envy* admires the winner's skill and makes you work harder to climb up to their level.

• • •

In van de Ven's lab tests, volunteers nudged to feel benign envy toward a high-performing student spent 35 percent longer solving difficult puzzles afterward than control students. By contrast, volunteers who felt malicious envy wasted their energy complaining that the winner had an unfair advantage.

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Why does social media trigger so much quiet envy? Psychologist Ethan Kross tracked young adults using Facebook five times a day and found that scrolling through other people's vacation and party photos reliably lowered life satisfaction by evening. We compare our messy behind-the-scenes daily life against a highlight reel of everyone else's best five minutes.

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Unlike envy, romantic jealousy is wired to protect a bond from an intruder, and it starts surprisingly early. Psychologist Sybil Hart asked mothers to ignore their baby for one minute while cuddling a lifelike baby doll on their lap. Six-month-old babies frowned, kicked, and crawled over to push the plastic rival off their mother's knees.

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Dogs show the exact same three-way jealousy. At the University of California, San Diego, psychologist Christine Harris had dog owners pet and sweet-talk a mechanical stuffed dog that barked and wagged its tail. Seventy-eight percent of real pet dogs pushed or snapped at the fake dog, whereas almost none cared when their owner petted a plastic Halloween bucket.

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Economists call our obsession with out-earning the neighbors positional competition. In surveys by Harvard economists Sara Solnick and David Hemenway, half of all respondents preferred earning $50,000 a year in a world where neighbors earned $25,000 over earning $100,000 a year where neighbors earned $200,000, even when prices were identical.

CHAPTER 9

Embarrassment

Why Only Humans Blush and How Turning Red Wins Instant Forgiveness

In 1872, Charles Darwin called blushing the most peculiar and most human of all expressions. Dogs tuck their tails and chimps bare their teeth in submission. Yet no other animal on Earth turns bright red in the face when it trips on a sidewalk or forgets someone's name at a party.

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Why do your cheeks and ears turn red while the rest of your skin stays the same color? Unlike almost every other vein in the human body, the tiny veins just beneath the skin of the human face are lined with special beta-adrenaline sensors. Those sensors widen the blood vessels when adrenaline hits, flooding the cheeks with warm red blood in five seconds.

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You cannot blush when you are completely alone unless you imagine other people watching you. Even more maddening, the harder you try to stop yourself from blushing, the worse it gets. The moment someone points at you and remarks that your face is turning red, the extra rush of self-conscious adrenaline makes your cheeks burn twice as bright.

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In 2009, Dutch psychologists Corine Dijk and Peter de Jong discovered a clever trick to stop a blush in its tracks. When volunteers felt their face getting hot in front of a crowd, a friendly assistant invited them to try to blush as red as they possibly could. That paradox relaxed their anxiety and their cheek temperature dropped back to normal.

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For a long time, people assumed embarrassment was just a mild version of shame, but psychologist Dacher Keltner proved they have completely different facial signatures. A shamed person drops their head straight down in defeat. An embarrassed person looks down, turns their head to the side, touches their face or neck, and flashes a sheepish half-smile.

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Why would evolution wire a neon red sign onto our face that broadcasts our mistakes to everyone in the room? In a cooperative group, when you knock over a stack of fruit or break a small social rule, your neighbors need to know your motive. They want to know whether you did it on purpose or by accident.

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Because nobody can fake a blush on command, turning red is an honest, unforgeable apology written in blood across your cheeks. It tells the whole room in a single glance that you know you messed up. It also proves that you care what the group thinks of you and respect its rules.

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Experiments show that this automatic apology works like magic on spectators. Keltner and Matthew Feinberg showed volunteers videos of someone knocking over a store display or dropping a stack of papers. Viewers rated the clumsy person as significantly more trustworthy and likable if the person looked embarrassed and blushed afterward than if they stayed cool and unfazed.

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In fact, people who embarrass easily turn out to be the most generous and trustworthy partners in economic games. Feinberg had volunteers play trust games with real money and gave them the chance to split raffle tickets with a stranger. People who blushed and squirmed most when praised or teased gave away significantly more tickets than cool-headed players.

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Blind people who have never seen a human blush still turn red in the face when they realize they have made a social mistake in public. Their cheeks heat up in the exact same pattern as sighted people, proving that the blood-vessel wiring of the blush is built into the human nervous system before birth.

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We even feel embarrassed on behalf of complete strangers who make fools of themselves on stage—a feeling Germans call *Fremdschämen*, or secondhand embarrassment. Brain scans by psychologist Sören Krach show that watching

someone sing terribly off-key at a microphone or trip during a speech lights up our own pain and empathy circuits.

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Most of the embarrassing blunders that keep us awake at night went almost completely unnoticed by everyone else in the room. In a famous 2000 experiment at Cornell University, psychologist Thomas Gilovich asked nervous students to walk into a room wearing a huge, tacky Barry Manilow T-shirt. The wearers guessed that half the room noticed their shirt, when in reality fewer than one in four people even remembered seeing it.

CHAPTER 10

Laughter and Play

Ticklish Rats, Play Bows, and Why Group Laughter Bonds Strangers

For decades, scientists assumed humans were the only animals that laugh. Then in 1997 at Bowling Green State University, neuroscientist Jaak Panksepp turned on a high-frequency ultrasonic microphone while tickling young laboratory rats on the nape of the neck. He heard the rats chirping with rapid 50-kilohertz bursts of joy.

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Panksepp's rats did not just chirp when tickled. They loved it so much that they chased the researcher's hand around the cage, nuzzled his fingers, and begged to be tickled again. Later studies by primatologist Marina Davila Ross recorded rhythmic, panting laughter in tickled chimpanzees, bonobos, gorillas, and orangutans, proving laughter is at least ten million years old.

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Why is it completely impossible to tickle yourself? Neuroscientist Sarah-Jayne Blakemore at University College London scanned people in an fMRI machine during tickling tests. Whenever you move your own fingers toward your ribs, the cerebellum at the back of your brain calculates your hand's exact path in advance and cancels out the tickle alarm before your skin feels it.

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We think we laugh because someone told a funny joke, but neuroscientist Robert Provine proved otherwise after eavesdropping on 1,200 natural bursts of laughter in shopping malls and city sidewalks. Fewer than twenty percent of real-world laughs followed anything remotely witty. Most followed ordinary polite remarks about leaving or saying goodbye.

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Even more striking, Provine discovered that speakers actually laugh 46 percent more often than the people listening to them. Humans are also thirty times more likely to laugh out loud when they are with other people than when they are watching the exact same funny show alone on the couch.

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Just like smiles, there are two completely different kinds of laughter that come from different parts of the brain. In acoustic studies by psychologist Greg Bryant at UCLA, listeners from twenty-four different societies around the world heard one-second audio clips of laughter. They easily told apart spontaneous belly laughter from polite, conversational laughter.

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Across those twenty-four cultures, listeners could also tell inside a single second whether two people laughing together were old friends or strangers who had just met. When old friends laugh together, their pitch rises, speeds up, and

breaks into breathy, involuntary squeaks that strangers almost never produce during polite small talk.

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Why does a hard belly laugh leave you breathless and make your ribs ache? In evolutionary anthropologist Robin Dunbar's experiments at Oxford, fifteen minutes of genuine group laughter triggered a wave of natural brain endorphins that raised volunteers' physical pain thresholds by roughly ten percent. Shared laughter bonds large groups of people without having to groom them one by one.

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How do playing puppies, bear cubs, and human children roughhouse and tackle each other without starting a real fight? Biologist Marc Bekoff showed that dogs use a universal punctuation mark called the play bow—dropping onto their front elbows while keeping their rear end up and wagging their tail. That bow tells the playmate that every nip that follows is just pretend.

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When two rats or puppies play-wrestle, the bigger, stronger animal cannot just pin the smaller one every single time or the smaller one will quit playing. Panksepp discovered the 70-30 rule of animal play. Even if one animal is much stronger, it voluntarily lets the smaller playmate win and pin it at least thirty percent of the time just to keep the game going.

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Why do babies love the game of peekaboo before they can even speak a word? Developmental psychologists found that a baby's laugh during peekaboo marks the exact moment a tiny flash of tension resolves into safe surprise. That sudden shift from mild alarm to safety is the basic blueprint of almost every comedy routine on Earth.

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Laughter is so contagious that it has occasionally shut down entire schools. In January 1962 at a girls' boarding school in Kashasha, Tanganyika, a fit of giggling among three students spread from classroom to classroom and village to village. Roughly a thousand people were caught in waves of contagious laughing, forcing fourteen schools to close temporarily before the outbreak faded.

CHAPTER 11

Nostalgia

Swiss Mercenary Homesickness, Cold-Room Warmth, and How Old Songs Steady the Mind

For nearly three hundred years after the word was invented, nostalgia was considered a dangerous medical disease rather than a warm feeling. In 1688 in Basel, Swiss medical student Johannes Hofer stitched together two Greek words—*nostos* (returning home) and *algos* (pain). He used the term to diagnose young Swiss mercenaries fighting in lowland Europe who stopped eating, developed fevers, and wasted away pining for their mountain valleys.

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Swiss commanders noticed that a single trigger set off the illness faster than anything else: the *Kuhreihen*, a traditional alpine melody sung by cowherds calling cattle home in the mountains. The song triggered such intense homesickness among Swiss soldiers serving in the French army that commanders banned troops from whistling or playing the tune on pain of death.

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Unlike pure happiness or pure sadness, nostalgia is almost always a bittersweet mix of both. Psychologists Constantine Sedikides and Tim Wildschut analyzed thousands of nostalgic stories from people across eighteen countries. Roughly

eighty percent combined warm affection for a past moment with a gentle ache that the moment is gone—yet the final mood at the end of the memory was overwhelmingly positive.

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What sets off a wave of nostalgia in everyday life? Contrary to what you might expect, people do not get nostalgic most often when they are already happy. Wildschut and Sedikides found that the number-one trigger of nostalgia is actually feeling lonely, bored, or uncertain after a big life change like moving to a new city.

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In 2012, psychologists Xinyue Zhou and Constantine Sedikides discovered a literal link between nostalgia and body temperature. Across thirty days of weather tracking and lab room tests, people felt noticeably more nostalgic on cold days or inside a chilly 16-degree Celsius room than in a warm 25-degree room. Asking volunteers in a cold room to recall a nostalgic memory made them guess the room was four degrees warmer.

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In that same study, volunteers who listened to a nostalgic song from their youth submerged their hand in a bucket of freezing 4-degree Celsius ice water. They were able to hold their hand in the ice water significantly longer than volunteers who listened to a cheerful modern pop song, showing that warm memories cushion physical discomfort.

• • •

Why can a single whiff of crayons, pine needles, or your grandmother's kitchen transport you back thirty years in a split second, far more vividly than looking at a photograph? Psychologists call this the Proust effect, after novelist Marcel Proust's famous memory of a tea-soaked madeleine cake.

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Neuroscientist Rachel Herz showed that smell is wired differently from every other human sense. Sights, sounds, and touches must first pass through the brain's central relay station before reaching memory hubs. By contrast, smell nerve fibers run straight from the nose into the amygdala and the memory-storing hippocampus with zero detours—making scent the fastest time machine in the brain.

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At what age do people form the memories and musical tastes they feel most nostalgic about for the rest of their lives? Memory researchers call the years between ages twelve and twenty-five the reminiscence bump. During those years, the teenage and young-adult brain is flooded with novelty-seeking dopamine while experiencing its first independence, first road trip, and first love.

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In 2010, psychologist Petr Janata put students inside an fMRI brain scanner while playing random top-40 pop songs from their youth. Whenever a song triggered strong nostalgia, it lit up the medial prefrontal cortex—the brain's autobio-

graphical self-hub. Because that area stays preserved late into Alzheimer's disease, dementia patients who cannot remember breakfast can still sing every word of songs from their teens.

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Although people think of nostalgia as looking backward, experiments show it actually makes people more optimistic about the future. When volunteers spend five minutes writing about a cherished past memory with family or friends, their sense of meaning in life rises. They also become more willing to take on new challenges and meet new people.

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Why do family holidays, birthday candles, and old recipes matter so much when life feels chaotic? Nostalgia acts like a mental anchor. Reminding yourself of who you loved and who loved you ten or twenty years ago reassures your brain that you are still the same connected person today, even when your job or house changes.

CHAPTER 12

Gratitude and Awe

Overview Astronauts, Towering Redwood Trees, and How Feeling Small Makes Us Generous

In 1971, as the *Apollo 14* lunar module lifted off from the Moon and the blue-and-white marble of Earth rose into the window, astronaut Edgar Mitchell felt an overwhelming wave of awe. Author Frank White later interviewed dozens of astronauts and named this shift the Overview Effect—the realization from orbit that borders vanish and all of humanity shares a paper-thin bubble of air.

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You do not need a rocket ticket to feel awe. In 2003, psychologists Dacher Keltner and Jonathan Haidt defined awe through two simple ingredients: encountering something vast—a canyon, a thunderstorm, a symphony, or a great idea—that stretches your normal frame of reference and forces you to update how you see the world.

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In 2015, psychologists Paul Piff and Dacher Keltner led half their student volunteers to stand inside a grove of 200-foot eucalyptus trees on the UC Berkeley campus for sixty seconds. The other half stared up at a modern science building of the same height. Seconds later, an experimenter walked past and accidentally dropped a handful of pens on the path.

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The students who had just spent one minute gazing up at the towering trees picked up significantly more pens for the stranger than the students who looked at the office building. Piff called this the small-self effect. When nature makes our own ego feel tiny, our daily worries shrink and we pay more attention to the people around us.

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In 2020, neurologist Virginia Sturm and Dacher Keltner prescribed weekly fifteen-minute awe walks to older adults, asking them to walk outdoors and look for vast or surprising details. After eight weeks, the awe walkers reported lower daily distress. In selfies they snapped along the trail, they literally placed their own faces smaller in the corner of the frame to show more of the world behind them.

• • •

What is that tingling wave of chills or goosebumps that runs down your neck and arms when a choir hits a soaring high note or a hero sacrifices himself in a movie? Psychologists call it *frisson*. It is a brief burst from the brain's reward hubs when music or a story builds tension, surprises your expectations, and opens into something larger than yourself.

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While awe opens our eyes to the wider world, gratitude is the glue that turns a one-time favor into a lasting friendship. Psychologist Sara Algoe calls gratitude the find, remind, and bind emotion. Feeling grateful spots a generous new friend,

reminds you that an old partner cares, and pulls the two of you closer together.

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People often confuse gratitude with feeling indebted, as if they just signed an IOU at a bank. In experiments by psychologist Philip Watkins, when a helper explicitly demanded that the recipient return the favor soon, warm gratitude vanished and turned into awkward obligation. Indebted people wanted to avoid the helper, whereas grateful people wanted to spend more time together.

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Even two words of genuine thanks change how people treat you. Psychologists Bruce Rind and David Strohmetz had a restaurant server write a simple thank-you note on the back of half her dinner checks before handing them to customers. Her average tip jumped from 16 percent to nearly 18 percent—an 11 percent raise for two seconds of ink.

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Being thanked does not just make you nicer to the person who thanked you; it makes you help complete strangers too. In experiments by Francesca Gino and Adam Grant, volunteers edited a student's cover letter and received either a neutral reply or a warm thank-you email. Sixty-six percent of thanked helpers volunteered to help a different stranger the next day, compared with only 32 percent of the unthanked group.

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In 2005, psychologist Martin Seligman tested half a dozen happiness exercises against one another in a randomized trial of 577 adults. The single biggest boost came from writing a 300-word gratitude letter to a teacher, parent, or friend you had never properly thanked and reading it to them in person. That single visit lifted happiness and cut sadness for a full month afterward.

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Why do we hesitate to send thank-you notes even when we feel grateful? In 2018, psychologists Amit Kumar and Nicholas Epley asked volunteers to write a short thank-you note to someone in their life and predict how the recipient would react. Writers consistently worried their note would sound awkward, whereas recipients rated the unexpected note as one of the warmest moments of their week.